

3,000 SQUARE YARDS of glass were used in the stained glass windows at Chartres cathedral. 152 out of 186 original stained glass windows at Chartres still survive today.



Ribbed vaulting helps to support the weight of the high, wide nave ceiling, the highest in France at the time it was built.

High pointed spires are made possible by pointed arches and flying buttresses, making Gothic buildings such as Chartres taller and lighter than any previous structures.

Chartres Cathedral

The great cathedral at Chartres is a striking example of the "Gothic" style of architecture that emerged in 12th-century France and flourished throughout the late medieval period. Gothic buildings, with their pointed arches, large windows, clustered columns, and soaring spires were intended to invoke the majesty and splendor of God. The main Gothic portion of Chartres was built in 1194–1220.

Flying buttresses surround and support the high walls and spires. Typically for a Gothic building, the buttresses at Chartres cathedral are turned into a decorative feature.

The west rose window depicts the Last Judgment. There are three rose windows in total, bathing the interior in a warm and golden light.



The royal portal features intricate carvings of religious scenes including Christ sitting in judgment. Statues of kings and queens symbolize the religious authority of the French monarchs.

The spacious nave is the widest in France and permits an unbroken view along the entire length of the cathedral.

Allegations of corruption and excess in the Church, as well as new ideas and forms of religious belief spread by new technology, undermined the unity of the Church.

THE REFORMATION

In the 16th century, the movement known as **the Reformation 256–59 >>** ended the religious unity of Western Europe and resulted in the establishment of **Protestant churches** that owed no allegiance to the pope. The catalyst for the Reformation came in 1517, when a priest named **Martin Luther** nailed a list of propositions to the door of the Castle church in Wittenberg, Germany. He intended to start a debate and, thanks to the new technology of the **printing press**, his ideas for reform of the Christian church were being read and discussed throughout Germany within two weeks and throughout Europe within a month.

By 1600, **Lutheran** churches were established in Germany and Scandinavia, **Calvinist** churches in Scotland, Switzerland, and the Netherlands, and **Anglican** churches in England and Wales.



THE GREAT BIBLE

VERNACULAR BIBLES

For **Luther**, as for other Protestant reformers such as **Calvin** and **Zwingli**, the authority to oppose the Church came from **Holy Scripture**, the **direct word of God**. To make holy writ readily available to ordinary men and women it had to be translated from **Latin**—the language of the clerical elite—into the **vernacular**, the spoken languages of everyday life. Luther lost no time in **translating the Bible** into German. This Bible facilitated the spread of Lutheranism from Germany to Scandinavia, Poland, and Hungary. Elsewhere, the momentum for the production of **printed Bibles in the vernacular** was equally unstoppable. The **first authorized edition of the scriptures in English**, the Great Bible, was produced by Miles Coverdale and published in 1538.

“Where there is charity and wisdom, there is neither fear nor ignorance.”

ST. FRANCIS OF ASSISI, “ADMONITIONS,” c. 1220